Phrases, Expressions & Idioms

1. Feelings, Emotions & Personal Experiences

1. Rough day

Meaning: A very difficult or unpleasant day
Example: I had a rough day at work today, so I decided to relax in the evening.

2. Butterflies in my stomach

Meaning: A nervous feeling
Example: I had butterflies in my stomach before giving my first presentation.

3. Cold feet

Meaning: Suddenly feeling nervous about something
Example: I got cold feet before the interview because I was unsure about my chances.

4. Worried sick

Meaning: Extremely worried
Example: My parents were worried sick when I did not return home on time.

5. On cloud nine

Meaning: Extremely happy
Example: I was on cloud nine when I found out that I had achieved my target score.

6. Under the weather

Meaning: Feeling slightly ill
Example: I was feeling under the weather, so I stayed home and got some rest.

7. Up in arms

Meaning: Extremely angry or upset
Example: Local residents were up in arms about the sudden increase in transportation costs.

8. Keep your chin up

Meaning: Stay positive during a difficult situation
Example: I told my friend to keep her chin up because setbacks are part of life.

9. Wear your heart on your sleeve

Meaning: Show your emotions openly
Example: She wears her heart on her sleeve, so it is easy to know how she feels.

10. Blow off steam

Meaning: Release stress or anger
Example: I usually go for a long walk to blow off steam after a stressful day.

2. Problems, Challenges & Difficult Situations

11. On the verge of

Meaning: Very close to doing something
Example: The company was on the verge of closing before it received new investment.

12. Not out of the woods yet

Meaning: Still facing difficulties
Example: The situation has improved, but we are not out of the woods yet.

13. In hot water

Meaning: In trouble
Example: The company found itself in hot water after failing to follow safety regulations.

14. The last straw

Meaning: The final problem that makes a situation unbearable
Example: The sudden cancellation of the project was the last straw for many employees.

15. The elephant in the room

Meaning: An obvious problem that people avoid discussing
Example: Unemployment is the elephant in the room whenever economic development is discussed.

16. Tip of the iceberg

Meaning: A small visible part of a much larger problem
Example: The pollution we can see is only the tip of the iceberg.

17. A wake-up call

Meaning: An event that makes someone realise something important
Example: Failing my first exam was a wake-up call that made me take my studies more seriously.

18. Back to square one

Meaning: Having to start again
Example: When the plan failed, we were forced to go back to square one.

19. Bite the bullet

Meaning: Face a difficult situation bravely
Example: I decided to bite the bullet and apply for the scholarship despite my doubts.

20. Face the music

Meaning: Accept the consequences of your actions
Example: Eventually, the company had to face the music after making several serious mistakes.

21. Bite off more than you can chew

Meaning: Take on more responsibility than you can manage
Example: I realised that I had bitten off more than I could chew by taking three courses simultaneously.

22. Cry over spilled milk

Meaning: Waste time regretting something that cannot be changed
Example: There is no point crying over spilled milk; we should focus on finding a solution.

23. Throw in the towel

Meaning: Give up
Example: Although the project was difficult, we refused to throw in the towel.

3. Communication & Conversation

24. How come?

Meaning: Why?
Example: How come you decided to change your career path?

25. Don’t get me wrong

Meaning: Do not misunderstand what I mean
Example: Don’t get me wrong, I appreciate technology, but I think we rely on it too much.

26. Cut to the chase

Meaning: Get directly to the main point
Example: To cut to the chase, I believe education is the key to reducing inequality.

27. Beat around the bush

Meaning: Avoid talking directly about the main issue
Example: Instead of beating around the bush, I think we should discuss the real problem.

28. Put your cards on the table

Meaning: Be completely honest and open
Example: I think it is better to put our cards on the table before making such an important decision.

29. Hit the nail on the head

Meaning: Say something exactly right
Example: You hit the nail on the head when you said that poor planning was the main cause of the problem.

30. Give them a hand

Meaning: Applaud or appreciate someone
Example: Let’s give them a hand for their outstanding performance.

31. That’s more like it

Meaning: This is better than before
Example: Your second presentation was much clearer; that’s more like it.

32. I’m all ears

Meaning: I am listening carefully
Example: If you have any suggestions for improving the project, I’m all ears.

33. Make a long story short

Meaning: Give the main information briefly
Example: To make a long story short, we missed the train and had to take a taxi.

34. Let the cat out of the bag

Meaning: Reveal a secret
Example: My brother accidentally let the cat out of the bag about the surprise party.

4. Thinking, Decisions & Opinions

35. I can't make up my mind

Meaning: I cannot decide
Example: I can't make up my mind about whether I should study abroad or stay in my hometown.

36. Go with your gut

Meaning: Follow your instinct
Example: When I am faced with a difficult decision, I usually go with my gut.

37. Devil's advocate

Meaning: Someone who argues the opposite side to test an idea
Example: Playing devil's advocate, I would argue that social media can also have educational benefits.

38. Take it with a grain of salt

Meaning: Do not completely believe something
Example: I would take information from social media with a grain of salt because it is not always reliable.

39. Sit on the fence

Meaning: Avoid choosing a side
Example: When it comes to environmental issues, governments cannot afford to sit on the fence.

40. Actions speak louder than words

Meaning: What people do is more important than what they say
Example: Politicians can make impressive promises, but actions speak louder than words.

41. See eye to eye

Meaning: Completely agree
Example: My parents and I do not always see eye to eye on career choices.

42. Go against the grain

Meaning: Do something differently from what is usual or expected
Example: Choosing a creative career went against the grain in my traditional family.

43. That's a whole new ballgame

Meaning: A completely different situation
Example: Studying at university is a whole new ballgame compared with studying at school.

5. Work, Study & Achievement

44. Wrap up

Meaning: Finish something
Example: We need to wrap up the meeting before the next session begins.

45. Get down to business

Meaning: Start working seriously
Example: After a short discussion, we got down to business and started planning the project.

46. Working behind the scenes

Meaning: Working without being publicly visible
Example: Several people were working behind the scenes to make the event successful.

47. Short on time

Meaning: Having very little time
Example: I was short on time, so I had to prioritise the most important tasks.

48. An all-nighter

Meaning: Staying awake throughout the night to work or study
Example: I pulled an all-nighter before my final exam, although I would not recommend it.

49. Hit the ground running

Meaning: Start something quickly and energetically
Example: I wanted to hit the ground running when I started my new job.

50. Go the extra mile

Meaning: Do more than is expected
Example: Good teachers often go the extra mile to support students who are struggling.

51. Burn the midnight oil

Meaning: Work or study late into the night
Example: I had to burn the midnight oil to complete my assignment before the deadline.

52. Keep the ball rolling

Meaning: Continue making progress
Example: We should keep the ball rolling instead of delaying the decision.

53. Pull that off

Meaning: Successfully accomplish something difficult
Example: I am impressed that she managed to pull that off under such pressure.

54. Put your best foot forward

Meaning: Make your best effort
Example: I always try to put my best foot forward during an interview.

55. A second wind

Meaning: A new burst of energy
Example: After taking a short break, I got a second wind and finished the assignment.

56. Tricks of the trade

Meaning: Special skills or techniques needed for a particular job
Example: Experienced teachers know many tricks of the trade that they learn through years of practice.

57. Call it a day

Meaning: Stop working for the day
Example: We have completed the main tasks, so I think we can call it a day.

6. Travel, Places & Experiences

58. A bird's-eye view

Meaning: A view from above
Example: From the top of the tower, we had a bird's-eye view of the entire city.

59. Hit the road

Meaning: Start a journey
Example: We decided to hit the road early to avoid heavy traffic.

60. At the crack of dawn

Meaning: Very early in the morning
Example: We left for the airport at the crack of dawn.

61. Off the beaten path

Meaning: A less common or unusual place
Example: I prefer travelling to destinations that are off the beaten path.

62. I'll drop by

Meaning: Visit for a short time
Example: I'll drop by your house this evening if I have enough time.

63. Ride shotgun

Meaning: Sit in the front passenger seat of a car
Example: I called shotgun because I wanted to enjoy the view from the front.

64. Ready to roll

Meaning: Ready to start
Example: We packed everything the night before, so we were ready to roll early in the morning.

7. Easy, Difficult & Successful Situations

65. A piece of cake

Meaning: Very easy
Example: Once I understood the instructions, the task was a piece of cake.

66. It was a breeze

Meaning: Very easy
Example: The interview was a breeze because I had prepared thoroughly.

67. Give it a shot

Meaning: Try something
Example: I had never tried public speaking before, but I decided to give it a shot.

68. Kill two birds with one stone

Meaning: Achieve two things with one action
Example: I cycled to work, which allowed me to exercise and save money, so I killed two birds with one stone.

69. Break the ice

Meaning: Start a conversation and make people feel comfortable
Example: The teacher told a funny story to break the ice at the beginning of the workshop.

70. Best of both worlds

Meaning: Enjoy two different advantages at the same time
Example: Working remotely gives me the best of both worlds because I have flexibility as well as a stable income.

71. Whole nine yards

Meaning: Everything possible
Example: For my sister's wedding, my family went the whole nine yards.

72. The ball is in your court

Meaning: It is now your decision or responsibility
Example: I have explained all the options, so now the ball is in your court.

73. Make ends meet

Meaning: Manage to cover living expenses
Example: Many families struggle to make ends meet because the cost of living has increased.

8. Money & Financial Situations

74. That's a steal

Meaning: Something is available at a very cheap price
Example: I bought this laptop for half the original price, so I think it was a steal.

75. Make ends meet

Meaning: Have enough money to cover basic expenses
Example: Young families often struggle to make ends meet in expensive cities.

76. Rags to riches

Meaning: From extreme poverty to great wealth
Example: His story is a classic rags-to-riches story that has inspired thousands of people.

9. Relationships & People

77. Apple of my eye

Meaning: Someone who is extremely dear to you
Example: My younger sister is the apple of my eye.

78. Through thick and thin

Meaning: During both good and difficult times
Example: My closest friends have supported me through thick and thin.

79. Cold shoulder

Meaning: Deliberately ignore someone
Example: She gave me the cold shoulder after our disagreement.

80. Pull someone's leg

Meaning: Joke with someone
Example: Don't take him seriously; he was just pulling your leg.

81. Fall head over heels

Meaning: Fall deeply in love
Example: He fell head over heels in love with her after they met at university.

82. Wolf in sheep's clothing

Meaning: A dangerous person who appears harmless
Example: He appeared friendly at first, but eventually we realised he was a wolf in sheep's clothing.

10. Change, Progress & Personal Growth

83. Turn my life around

Meaning: Completely change your life for the better
Example: Getting a scholarship helped me turn my life around and pursue my ambitions.

84. Blessing in disguise

Meaning: Something that initially seems bad but eventually has a positive result
Example: Losing that job was a blessing in disguise because it encouraged me to pursue a better career.

85. Second wind

Meaning: A renewed feeling of energy
Example: After a short break, I got a second wind and continued working.

86. Keep your chin up

Meaning: Remain positive during difficulties
Example: My teacher told me to keep my chin up after I received disappointing results.

87. A wake-up call

Meaning: An experience that makes someone realise the seriousness of a situation
Example: The health scare was a wake-up call that encouraged him to adopt a healthier lifestyle.

11. Opportunities, Risk & Choices

88. Miss the boat

Meaning: Miss an opportunity
Example: If we do not invest in renewable energy now, we may miss the boat.

89. Don’t put all your eggs in one basket

Meaning: Do not depend entirely on one option
Example: Students should not put all their eggs in one basket when applying for universities.

90. Shoot for the moon

Meaning: Aim for a very ambitious goal
Example: I believe young people should shoot for the moon rather than limit themselves unnecessarily.

91. At the drop of a hat

Meaning: Immediately and without hesitation
Example: My brother is willing to travel at the drop of a hat.

92. Whatever floats your boat

Meaning: Do whatever makes you happy
Example: Some people enjoy travelling alone, while others prefer group tours; whatever floats your boat.

12. Truth, Secrets & Information

93. Lost in translation

Meaning: The original meaning becomes unclear when translated into another language
Example: Some cultural references were lost in translation when the film was translated into English.

94. Let the cat out of the bag

Meaning: Accidentally reveal a secret
Example: My friend let the cat out of the bag and ruined the surprise.

95. No smoke without fire

Meaning: Rumours may have some truth behind them
Example: People often say there is no smoke without fire, although rumours should still be treated cautiously.

96. Take it with a grain of salt

Meaning: Do not accept something as completely true
Example: I would take online reviews with a grain of salt because they can sometimes be misleading.

97. X marks the spot

Meaning: Indicates the exact location
Example: According to the map, X marks the spot where the treasure was supposedly buried.

13. Mistakes, Consequences & Responsibility

98. Face the music

Meaning: Accept the consequences of your actions
Example: After making a serious mistake, he decided to face the music rather than blame someone else.

99. Get your act together

Meaning: Improve your behaviour or organisation
Example: I realised I needed to get my act together if I wanted to achieve my academic goals.

100. Cut corners

Meaning: Do something in an easier or cheaper way, often sacrificing quality
Example: Companies should never cut corners when it comes to public safety.

101. Rub salt in the wound

Meaning: Make an unpleasant situation even worse
Example: Losing the competition was disappointing, and hearing negative comments afterwards only rubbed salt in the wound.

102. Rain on your parade

Meaning: Spoil someone's happiness or excitement
Example: I do not want to rain on your parade, but you should consider the possible risks.

103. Turn a blind eye

Meaning: Deliberately ignore something
Example: Governments should not turn a blind eye to environmental pollution.

104. Slip through the cracks

Meaning: Be overlooked or missed
Example: Some vulnerable children may slip through the cracks of the education system.

105. Get a taste of your own medicine

Meaning: Experience the same negative treatment that you have given others
Example: After constantly criticising his colleagues, he eventually got a taste of his own medicine.

14. Situations, Reactions & Everyday Expressions

106. You're kidding

Meaning: You are joking or not being serious
Example: You're kidding! I cannot believe you actually won the competition.

107. Hands-down

Meaning: Definitely or without doubt
Example: This is hands-down the most impressive museum I have ever visited.

108. Packed

Meaning: Extremely full or crowded
Example: The shopping centre was packed with people during the holiday season.

109. That's more like it

Meaning: This is better than before
Example: Your second attempt is much clearer; that's more like it.

110. Calm before the storm

Meaning: A peaceful period before difficulties begin
Example: The quiet morning felt like the calm before the storm because we knew the election results would create controversy.

111. Storm in a teacup

Meaning: A small issue that has been made to seem much more serious
Example: Their disagreement was just a storm in a teacup and was resolved within a few hours.

112. When pigs fly

Meaning: Something will probably never happen
Example: He will apologise when pigs fly.

113. Let sleeping dogs lie

Meaning: Avoid bringing an old problem back into discussion
Example: I think we should let sleeping dogs lie and focus on solving the current problem.

114. Let sleeping giants lie

Meaning: Avoid disturbing a powerful situation or creating unnecessary trouble
Example: The company decided to let sleeping giants lie rather than enter a risky legal battle.

15. Attention, Awareness & Caution

115. Keep your eyes peeled

Meaning: Watch carefully and stay alert
Example: Keep your eyes peeled for any signs indicating the correct route.

116. I'll keep an eye out

Meaning: Watch carefully for something
Example: I'll keep an eye out for any opportunities that might suit you.

117. Walk on eggshells

Meaning: Be extremely careful about what you say or do
Example: Employees often feel they have to walk on eggshells around an overly demanding manager.

118. Bigger fish to fry

Meaning: Have more important things to deal with
Example: I cannot worry about that minor issue because I have bigger fish to fry.

119. A bird's-eye view

Meaning: A view from above or a broad overall perspective
Example: The report gives us a bird's-eye view of the country's economic situation.

16. Success, Failure & Motivation

120. Break a leg

Meaning: Good luck
Example: I told my friend to break a leg before her first stage performance.

121. Keep the ball rolling

Meaning: Continue progress
Example: We have made good progress, so we should keep the ball rolling.

122. Put your best foot forward

Meaning: Make your best effort
Example: I always try to put my best foot forward when meeting new people.

123. Go the extra mile

Meaning: Make an additional effort
Example: Teachers who go the extra mile can have a lasting impact on their students.

124. The whole nine yards

Meaning: Everything possible
Example: For the graduation ceremony, the organisers went the whole nine yards.

125. Throw in the towel

Meaning: Give up
Example: Even after several failures, she refused to throw in the towel.

126. Hit the ground running

Meaning: Start something quickly and energetically
Example: I want to hit the ground running when I begin my new position.

127. Rags to riches

Meaning: A journey from poverty to wealth or success
Example: His rags-to-riches story demonstrates how determination can transform someone's life.

128. Icing on the cake

Meaning: An additional benefit that makes a good situation even better
Example: Winning the award was the icing on the cake after an already successful year.

Band 9 Speaking Reminder

These expressions are most effective when they are used naturally and appropriately.

Use them with: **Clear ideas + precise vocabulary + natural expressions + relevant examples**

Do not try to use an idiom in every answer. A few well-placed expressions can make your speech sound much more natural than memorising large numbers of idioms.

Example:

Instead of: I was very nervous before my presentation.

You could say:I had butterflies in my stomach before my presentation, but once I started speaking, I gradually became more confident.